

the 1920s, there was an anti-Nautch Movement in Madras, demanding the legal prohibition of dance performances since they were presumed to lead to prostitution; by 1932, the entirely-Brahmin Madras Music Academy had invented a new name for the dance, 'Bharatanatyam', and made its acquisition a mark of accomplishment for middle-class girls in the marriage market.

Every one of these processes involved the 'ethnic cleansing' of the forms, virtually a war on the lower castes that had kept the arts alive since antiquity. As many art forms were taken up by the middle-classes, those communities that had kept the arts alive were pushed away from the newly-opening market for culture and sank lower into degradation. We hear no more of devadasis or mirasis.

Modern technology has added to the pace of change. Gramophone records made classical

has thrown the normal economic structure of the cities into disarray, making the young wealthy. With the computer becoming the central icon of our daily life, even the poor have started sending their children to expensive English-medium schools, and concern is being expressed that some of our regional languages may die out entirely. Call centres have become the feared symbols of our future lobotomisation.

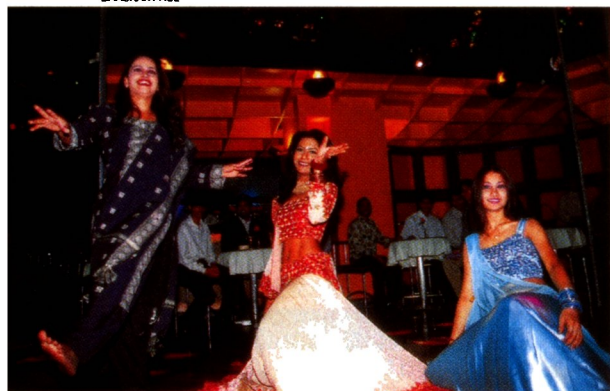
On the other side, when terrestrial television came to India, there were fears of wholesale globalisation of entertainment and news channels, which did not happen. Most new channels in the last few years have been in regional languages, giving a whole new lease of life to these languages, providing employment to all those who live by the spoken language. You don't need to be literate to make a fortune.

The process of acceptance of 'culture' (or 'cultures') by the urban middle-class has

“A true democracy cannot deny its citizens the right to live. Let us strive to provide every citizen of this country equal rights and opportunities.”

ADOOR
GOPALAKRISHNAN
Filmmaker

BHASKAR PAUL



music, confined until then to palaces and kothas, accessible to the common person of means, and the radio took it to anyone who cared to listen. Film music has come to be accepted as a truly national medium, acknowledged even by the new generation of the NRIs. Today, in our countryside the audio-cassette has taken music to the women working in the fields, and any schoolboy with a mobile can become a photographer. Thanks to cement concrete, steel and oil paint, anyone with the means can get his house built to his own design, without the foggiest notion about architecture.

And suddenly, we are faced with the electronic explosion! What impact it may have boggles the imagination. Information Technology, we hope, will help bridge the knowledge divide that has kept our villages lagging far behind the cities, thanks to the colonial habit of situating every important administrative and educational institution in the capital city. But it

THE HOSTILITY OF OUR AUTHORITIES TO NIGHT CLUBS REACHES BACK INTO THE ANTI-NAUTCH HYSTERIA OF A CENTURY AGO.

brought in with it fears of the 'unacceptable' and the 'corrupting', and a new, scary obsession with respectability. The hostility of our politicians and police to cabaret girls, late-night bands and night clubs reaches directly back into the anti-Nautch hysteria of a century ago. We have Dalits who find the traditional practice of pooja by naked women in their community shameful and Hindu ideologues who deny, despite all evidence, that Hindu goddesses were ever depicted naked. 'Hounding Husain' is an activity which finds support in political circles as well as elegant salons.

Our cities explode pell-mell, riding roughshod over the urban poor, in a hurry to catch up with Beijing or Shanghai. We need only see—how can we avoid seeing it?—the half-a-dozen skyscrapers erected in the heart of Bangalore by a liquor-cum-airlines billionaire. This was his opportunity to lead India into the Hall of Fame for Architecture, to project Kannada creativity in architecture. Instead, what we have are caricatures of the Empire State Building and the Chrysler—1,500 years of Karnataka architecture culminating resplendently in global kitsch. And, as if that weren't agony enough, the chief minister is threatening to build a hundred-storey 'tower' in the green heart of this congested city, as a 'monument'—to what culture? ■



Girish Karnad is a well-known playwright, actor and director.